DSA REFERENCE

Heap and Priority Queue Problem Ladder

A sequenced practice ladder from warm-up to interview stretch.

Keep the next best candidate accessible while updates cost logarithmic time instead of repeatedly sorting everything.

VERSION 1.0 REVIEW

REVIEWED THROUGH 2026-07-18

STATUS HUMAN REVIEW REQUIRED

DSA / HEAP-PRIORITY-QUEUE

DSA

Heap and Priority Queue Problem Ladder

CORE IDEA

Keep the next best candidate accessible while updates cost logarithmic time instead of repeatedly sorting everything.

Recognition cues

+ top k
+ streaming minimum or maximum
+ merge sorted inputs
+ schedule next event

Implementation sequence

+ choose min-heap or max-heap
+ store tie-breakers
+ bound heap size for top k
+ remove stale entries when using lazy deletion

Invariant

The root is the best element under the chosen ordering; heap contents are exactly the active candidates.

Worked reasoning

For top k largest values, keep a min-heap of size k; its root is the cutoff.

Complexity

O(log k) per bounded update and O(k) space; full heap construction can be O(n).

Failure modes

- [ ] reversing heap direction
- [ ] unstable tuple comparisons
- [ ] forgetting stale entries
- [ ] sorting when incremental answers are required

Practice ladder

Heap and Priority Queue Problem Ladder: referenced problems

Open the official problem page, classify the pattern, write the invariant, and predict the complexity before coding.

#	Problem	Deliberate-practice prompt
1	**Kth Largest Element**	State the cue, invariant, edge case, and proof before implementation.
2	**Top K Frequent Elements**	State the cue, invariant, edge case, and proof before implementation.
3	**Find Median from Data Stream**	State the cue, invariant, edge case, and proof before implementation.
4	**Merge K Sorted Lists**	State the cue, invariant, edge case, and proof before implementation.
5	**Task Scheduler**	State the cue, invariant, edge case, and proof before implementation.

Before coding

+ Pattern cue
+ State
+ Invariant
+ Boundary convention

Before finishing

+ Dry run
+ Edge case
+ Time proof
+ Space proof

PUBLISHING STATUS

REVIEW GATE: STABLE TECHNICAL. AI-produced draft. A named human must verify technical accuracy, sourcing, freshness, and editorial quality before publication. Reviewed-through date: 2026-07-18.